

THE COMPLETE STARTER KIT FOR FIRST-TIME ASPIRANTS

UPSC 2027

Foundation Planner

Prelims: 23 May 2027 • Notification: 13 January 2027

Your 8-month roadmap from zero to Prelims day

2027

8-MONTH

PHASED ROADMAP

12

SECTIONS

20+

TABLES & TRACKERS

100%

OFFICIAL FACTS

SECTION 1

Start Here: What This Planner Does

You have roughly eight months until the UPSC Civil Services (Preliminary) Examination 2027 on 23 May 2027. That is enough time to build a serious first attempt — if you spend it on the right things. This planner turns the official exam information and a proven preparation sequence into one document you can follow weekly.

What you get in this planner

- The complete official 2027 timeline and the exam pattern in numbers — verified from upsc.gov.in.
- An 8-month, four-phase roadmap from this week to Prelims morning, with monthly milestones.
- A lean, fixed booklist — NCERTs plus one standard book per subject — and the rules for using it.
- Three ready daily timetables: full-time aspirant, working professional, and college student.
- The current-affairs workflow, the CSAT safety plan, and the Prelims attempt math — exactly how many questions at what accuracy clear the cut-off.
- The 13 January – 2 February 2027 application checklist, with the traps that reject forms.
- The notes-and-revision recall system, a first look at Mains and Interview, a weekly tracker template, and the fifteen beginner mistakes that quietly end attempts.

How to use it: read Sections 2–4 today (30 minutes), set up your booklist and timetable this week (Sections 5–8), then live inside the weekly tracker (Section 16) until May. Everything dated is official; everything strategic is a recommendation you can adapt to your life.

SECTION 2

The Exam in Numbers

Three stages, about a year from application to final list, and roughly ten lakh candidates at the gate. Here is exactly what the machine looks like before you feed a single hour into it.

Stage 1 — Preliminary Examination (23 May 2027)

Paper	Questions	Marks	Duration	Role
General Studies Paper I	100 × 2 marks	200	2 hours	Merit — decides your cut-off
General Studies Paper II (CSAT)	80 × 2.5 marks	200	2 hours	Qualifying — 33% (66 marks) needed

- Negative marking: one-third of the question's marks — -0.66 per wrong GS answer, -0.83 per wrong CSAT answer. Blank answers carry no penalty.
- Both papers are set in Hindi and English, on the same day.
- Prelims marks are never counted in the final merit. It is purely a gate to the Mains.
- About 12 to 13 times the number of vacancies clear Prelims for Mains — with roughly 950–1,000 recent vacancies, that means roughly 11,000–13,000 candidates move forward each year.

Stage 2 — Main Examination (from 20 August 2027, 5 days)

Paper	Subject	Marks
Paper A	Indian language (Eighth Schedule) — qualifying	300
Paper B	English — qualifying	300
Paper I	Essay	250
Paper II	General Studies I (Heritage, History, Geography, Society)	250
Paper III	General Studies II (Polity, Governance, Social Justice, IR)	250
Paper IV	General Studies III (Economy, Agriculture, S&T, Environment, DM)	250
Paper V	General Studies IV (Ethics, Integrity, Aptitude)	250
Paper VI	Optional Subject — Paper I	250
Paper VII	Optional Subject — Paper II	250
Total (written)	Papers I–VII counted for merit	1750

- Stage 3 — Personality Test (Interview): 275 marks, no minimum qualifying marks. About twice the number of vacancies are summoned.
- Final merit = 1750 (written) + 275 (interview) = 2025 marks.
- Both Mains language papers are qualifying; you must clear them for the other papers to be counted.

What the cut-off actually looks like (official CSE 2025)

Stage	General	EWS	OBC	SC	ST
Prelims (GS-I, out of 200)	92.66	89.34	92.00	84.00	82.66
Mains (out of 1750)	739	706	717	700	694
Final (out of 2025)	963	926	931	905	902

Read the Prelims row carefully: the general cut-off has swung between 75 and 98 over the last seven years (2023: 75.41 • 2024: 87.98 • 2025: 92.66). That means roughly 46–50% of GS Paper I is enough to clear Prelims in a typical year — accuracy and elimination matter more than knowing everything.

Planning number: aim to comfortably score 100+ in GS Paper I on mocks (a 25-question buffer above the recent cut-off band) and 90+ in CSAT. Build every week of this planner backwards from those two targets.

SECTION 3

The Official 2027 Timeline

Released by UPSC in its annual calendar of 20 May 2026. Put these five dates in your phone today — then check upsc.gov.in weekly, because the Commission can alter them.

Event	Date	What it means for you
Notification opens	13 January 2027	Official rules, vacancies and syllabus for CSE 2027 drop. Your eligibility questions get final answers.
Applications close	2 February 2027, 6:00 PM	Hard deadline. No withdrawal is allowed after you submit. Apply in the first week.
Preliminary Examination	23 May 2027 (Sunday)	GS Paper I + CSAT, one day, offline across India. IFoS Prelims is held through the same paper.
Main Examination	From 20 August 2027 (5 days)	Nine written papers, descriptive. Only if you clear Prelims.
Personality Test	Early 2028 (expected)	About twice the vacancies are summoned; 275 marks.

Recent vacancy trend — the size of the prize

Cycle	Vacancies	Prelims date
CSE 2024	1,105	16 June 2024
CSE 2025	979	25 May 2025
CSE 2026	933 (33 reserved for PwBD)	24 May 2026

More than ten lakh candidates apply each cycle. Roughly 12–13 times the vacancies clear Prelims, and about twice the vacancies reach the interview. Selection is a narrowing funnel — your job in the next eight months is only to be on the right side of the first gate.

SECTION 4

Are You Eligible? Attempts, Age, Fees

The rules below are from the CSE 2026 notification — the latest published. The CSE 2027 notification on 13 January 2027 is the final word, and this pattern has been stable for years, but verify your own case against it.

Who can sit

- Age: you must be at least 21 and not more than 32 on 1 August of the exam year (for 2027: born not earlier than 2 August 1995 and not later than 1 August 2006, if the rule carries over unchanged).
- Education: a bachelor's degree from a recognised university. Any stream — engineers, doctors, commerce and arts graduates all sit the same paper.
- Final-year students: you can appear in Prelims; you must produce proof of passing with your Mains application (Detailed Application Form).
- Nationality: Indian citizenship is required for the IAS, IFS and IPS; other services also accept subjects of Nepal/Bhutan and certain refugees.

Age relaxations

Category	Relaxation
SC / ST	Up to 5 years

Category	Relaxation
OBC	Up to 3 years
Defence Services personnel disabled in operations	Up to 3 years
Ex-servicemen	Up to 5 years (conditions apply)
Persons with Benchmark Disability	Up to 10 years

Attempts — count them before you spend one

Category	Attempts
General / EWS	6
OBC	9
SC / ST	Unlimited (within the age limit)
PwBD (General / EWS / OBC)	9
PwBD (SC / ST)	Unlimited

Critical rule: appearing in even one paper of the Preliminary Examination counts as an attempt — even if you never touch the second paper. Do not “test the water” casually; a wasted attempt is gone forever.

Fees

Stage	Fee	Exempt
Prelims	■100	Female, SC, ST and PwBD candidates
Mains (only if you clear Prelims)	■200	Female, SC, ST and PwBD candidates

Payments are online (net banking, cards, UPI) through the UPSC online portal. There is no refund and no application withdrawal — treat the submit button as final.

SECTION 5

The 8-Month Roadmap: September 2026 to May 2027

Four phases, each with a single job. Built for someone starting from zero today; if you are restarting, enter at the phase that matches your syllabus coverage. Working professionals: see the adapted hours in Section 8.

Phase 1 — Foundation (now → end of November 2026)

One job: build the base and lock your system.

Month	Milestones	Weekly rhythm
September 2026	Download and read the Prelims + Mains syllabus twice. Skim 5 years of Prelims PYQs. Start Polity (NCERT + Laxmikanth) and daily newspaper. Take one CSAT diagnostic paper.	30–35 hrs
October 2026	Finish NCERT core: Geography + Economy. Choose your Optional by 31 October — no more dithering. Start Modern History (Spectrum).	35–40 hrs
November 2026	Complete Polity first pass with notes. Environment + Science-Tech basics from NCERT/standard source. Begin Optional first pass (25–30% of syllabus).	35–40 hrs

Phase 2 — Consolidation (December 2026 → 15 February 2027)

One job: finish the static syllabus once and apply to the exam.

Window	Milestones	Weekly rhythm
December 2026	Finish Modern History + Art & Culture first pass. Optional to 50%. Start weekly answer writing (2 answers).	40 hrs
13 Jan – 2 Feb 2027	Notification live: verify eligibility, apply in week one (checklist in Section 12). Read the Economic Survey highlights and Union Budget coverage when released (Jan–Feb).	35–40 hrs
Early Feb 2027	First pass of full GS static syllabus done. First full-length subject tests. Optional to 60–65%.	40 hrs

Phase 3 — Prelims Mode (mid-February → mid-March 2027)

One job: convert reading into recall — revision + PYQs.

- Second reading of every subject, now from your own short notes, not the full book.
- Solve the last 15 years of Prelims PYQs subject by subject; log every wrong answer.
- Optional syllabus to 80%; Mains prep pauses here but your answer-writing habit does not fully stop (1 answer/week).
- Current affairs: consolidate 2026 months you covered, month-by-month, into one-line notes.

Phase 4 — Mock Season and Taper (mid-March → 23 May 2027)

Window	Milestones
Mid-March → mid-April	One full-length Prelims mock every week + full CSAT section. Error log after every mock: wrong concept, silly mistake, or guessed wrong. Target 25+ hours of mock analysis in this stretch.
Mid-April → 7 May	Two full mocks per week. Third revision of high-yield topics: Polity, Modern History, Environment, Economy basics, schemes. Current affairs revision from your one-line notes.
8 – 22 May	The taper: no new sources. Daily rapid revision + one mock every 2–3 days at the real 9:30 AM slot. Sleep on exam schedule. Last 2 days: only your notes, admit card, ID and travel plan.

After Prelims, the machine keeps rolling: Mains starts 20 August 2027. June–August belongs to answer writing, Essays, GS-IV Ethics and Optional completion. This planner deliberately front-loads reading and note-making so that window stays free for writing practice.

SECTION 6

The Booklist: One Book Per Subject

The single biggest beginner killer is the book pile. Your entire static preparation runs on this table — NCERTs plus one standard book per subject, revised five times each. Nothing else until Prelims is done.

Step 1 — NCERT base (free at ncert.nic.in)

Subject	NCERTs to read	Priority
Polity	Class 9–12 (Democratic Politics + Indian Constitution at Work)	Highest
History	Class 6–12 (themes: ancient, medieval, modern)	High
Geography	Class 6–12 (fundamentals + India: physical, economic)	High
Economy	Class 9–12 (Macroeconomics basics)	Medium
Environment	Class 12 Biology (ecology chapters)	Medium

Step 2 — Standard books (after the NCERT, not before)

Subject	Book	Notes
Polity	Indian Polity — M. Laxmikanth	The single most important book in UPSC prep. Read it 3+ times.
Modern History	A Brief History of Modern India — Spectrum	Exam-oriented and complete for Prelims + Mains GS-I.
Geography	Certificate Physical & Human Geography — G. C. Leong + a good atlas	Pair with map practice: locate every place in the news.
Economy	Indian Economy — Ramesh Singh (or Shankar Ganesh)	Read after NCERT macro; skip deep theory, focus on concepts in the news.

Subject	Book	Notes
Art & Culture	Indian Art and Culture — Nitin Singhania	Read selectively with the Prelims PYQ style in mind.
Environment	Environment — Shankar IAS	Highest Prelims weight per page; read with current affairs linkage.
Current Affairs	One daily newspaper + one monthly compilation	The Hindu OR Indian Express — pick one and never switch.

- Previous Year Questions: free and official on upsc.gov.in — the best study material that exists for this exam.
- Rule of one: one source per subject, revised five times, beats five sources read once.
- Do not buy a single book outside this list until you have finished it once. Telegram PDF hoarding is not preparation.

SECTION 7

Choosing Your Optional (Decide by 31 October)

Your Optional is 500 of the 1750 written marks — the biggest single lever you control. Beginners lose months switching subjects. Set a hard deadline of 31 October 2026 and commit.

The five-question test

- Interest: can you read this subject for 300 hours across a year without resenting it?
- Background: does it connect to your degree or work experience? (Not required — but a head start helps.)
- Overlap: does it feed your GS papers? (Popular overlaps: PSIR and Sociology into GS-II; Geography into GS-I; Public Administration into GS-II.)
- Material: are standard books, a PYQ bank and some guidance easily available?
- PYQ comfort: sit with the last 5 years of that subject's Mains papers. Could you eventually write these answers?

Method: pick two candidates, study each for one focused week in parallel (syllabus + 2 chapters + PYQs), score them on the five questions, and commit to the winner on 31 October. The toppers' cliché is true: any Optional works; switching Optionals does not.

SECTION 8

Three Daily Timetables

A timetable you actually follow beats a beautiful one you abandon in week two. Pick the shape that matches your life, then protect the anchors — fixed time blocks — even when the content changes.

Full-time aspirant (8–10 focused hours)

Bloc k	Time	Content
1	6:30 – 8:00 AM	Newspaper + current affairs notes (60–90 min, no more)
2	9:30 AM – 1:00 PM	Deep static study — the hardest subject first

Block	Time	Content
3	2:30 – 5:00 PM	Second subject / Optional
4	5:30 – 7:00 PM	Revision of the day + MCQs or answer writing (alternate days)
5	8:30 – 9:30 PM	Light revision: maps, notes, one CSAT set (alternate days)

Working professional (~25 hours a week)

Block	Time	Content
Weekdays	5:30 – 6:15 AM	Newspaper headlines + 1 current-affairs note
Weekdays	7:00 – 9:00 PM	Static subject (2 hrs, phone off, one subject per week)
Weekdays	10:00 – 10:30 PM	15 MCQs or revision flashcards
Saturday	4 × 90-min blocks	Catch-up + Optional + weekly test
Sunday	5–6 hrs	Revision of the whole week + mock + analysis + rest

- Your real advantage is consistency over 8 months — 25 focused hours a week done every week beats 60-hour hero weeks followed by burnout.
- One subject per week beats subject-juggling: your brain revises nightly and consolidates by Sunday.

College student (4–6 hours)

Block	Time	Content
Morning	45 min	Newspaper notes
Between classes	45–60 min	NCERT / revision flashcards
Evening	2 × 90 min	Static subject + Optional (alternate days)
Night	30 min	15 MCQs + quick recall of the day

Final-year students get a double benefit: much of Polity, Economy and Geography overlaps with general studies and interview awareness. Build the habit now; make 2028 your fully-loaded attempt if 2027 is a shot-in-progress.

SECTION 9

The Current-Affairs Workflow

Roughly a third of Prelims and a large share of Mains reward current affairs — but only ones linked to the static syllabus. The workflow below takes 60–90 minutes a day, forever, starting today.

- One newspaper, read daily: The Hindu or Indian Express. Never both, never switching. 45–60 minutes.
- Read with the syllabus beside you. An RBI policy story sends you back to your Economy notes; a Supreme Court ruling to Polity.
- Make one-line notes, not paragraphs: date, actor, issue, static link. If it doesn't map to a syllabus topic, it can wait.

- One monthly compilation at month-end: spend 2–3 hours consolidating, not re-reading the whole month.
- Skip daily current-affairs videos as a primary source — at most one weekly recap, treated as revision.
- Government sources beat noise: PIB highlights, the Economic Survey and the Budget in January–February are exam gold.

The integration rule: every current-affairs note must end with a link to static — “connects to Article 21 / fiscal deficit / Western Disturbances”. This one habit is what separates Mains answers that score from answers that merely fill pages.

SECTION 10

The CSAT Safety Plan

Every year, candidates with excellent GS scores fail Prelims because they ignored the qualifying paper. CSAT needs just 66 out of 200 — but it demands weekly practice, not zero, and not panic in April.

- This week: take one past CSAT paper (say, 2023) cold, timed 2 hours. Score yourself. Below 90? You have a project. Above 110? You need maintenance only.
- The three question families: reading comprehension, logical/analytical reasoning, and basic numeracy (Class-X level). Diagnose which one bleeds marks.
- Comprehension is the biggest chunk — it improves with volume: 2 passages a day from PYQs and standard practice sets.
- Weekly dose from now to April: one 30-minute sectional, rotating families; from April: one full 80-question CSAT with every mock.
- Watch the time trap: 80 questions in 120 minutes means under 90 seconds each. Practise leaving questions — a blank is free, a wrong answer costs 0.83.

Maths-phobic candidates: roughly 40–50% of CSAT marks are reachable through comprehension and reasoning alone when accuracy is high. Your goal is not to love maths; it is to bank 66+ with certainty.

SECTION 11

Prelims MCQ Strategy: The Attempt Math

GS Paper I is a negative-marking game, not a knowledge parade. Before you solve a single question, know your arithmetic: how many attempts, at what accuracy, get you to the 95-mark zone that has cleared every recent cut-off?

Accuracy needed to net $\approx$ 95 marks in GS Paper I

Attempts	Correct needed	Accuracy needed	Wrong answers cost
60	51 of 60	85%	–6.0 marks
75	57 of 75	76%	–12.0 marks
80	56 of 80	70%	–16.0 marks
90	58 of 90	65%	–21.3 marks

Attempts	Correct needed	Accuracy needed	Wrong answers cost
100	61 of 100	61%	−26.0 marks

Every 2-mark correct adds +2; every wrong answer burns −0.66. The more you attempt, the lower the accuracy you can afford — but only if your wrong answers come from near-misses, not wild guesses. Read the table as a personality test: precise-but-slow candidates should attempt 60–75 with high accuracy; fast readers can afford 90–100 at lower accuracy.

Four elimination habits

- Extreme-word filter: options with ‘only’, ‘always’, ‘never’, ‘completely’ are usually wrong in Polity and Economy questions.
- Two-similar-two-different: when two options are near-identical twins, the answer usually lives inside that pair — then decide the half-point between them.
- Statement-elimination: in multi-statement questions, verify the statement you are most sure about first; it often kills two options at once.
- The 50-50 discipline: if you can narrow to two options and have even a weak reason to prefer one, the math (2 versus −0.66) makes guessing profitable in aggregate — but never from zero elimination.

The Prelims-day protocol (23 May 2027)

Session	Paper	Starts	Entry closes
Morning	General Studies Paper I	9:30 AM	9:00 AM
Afternoon	CSAT (GS Paper II)	2:30 PM	2:00 PM

- Reach 60–90 minutes early; late entry is refused without exception — confirm final timings on your e-admit card.
- Carry: admit-card printout, the same photo ID you declared in the application, a black ballpoint pen (OMR is filled in black only), and two passport photos.
- Leave behind: phones, smartwatches, calculators, notes, wallets — the frisking is strict and excuses are not accepted.
- The three-hour gap is for eating light and resetting — not for post-mortems of Paper I. Walk out of the morning, walk into the afternoon.
- OMR discipline: fill circles fully, never overwrite; a double-marked answer scores zero.

SECTION 12

Notes & Revision: The Recall System

Reading is not preparation — recall is. This three-layer system turns one reading into three revisions, without your notes becoming a second book you never open.

The three layers

Layer	What it is	When made
1. Margin notes	Underline + one word in the margin while reading the book	First reading

Layer	What it is	When made
2. One-page subject notes	One page per topic: definitions, articles, committees, data points — in your own words	Evening of the same day
3. Flash layer	A final revision sheet per subject: 2–3 pages of only what you keep forgetting	First revision (within 7 days)

The spaced calendar

- First revision: within 7 days of first reading — from your one-page notes, not the book.
- Second revision: 3–4 weeks later — flash layer + 20 MCQs on the topic.
- Third revision: the final lap (May 2027) — flash layer only, at speed.
- Sunday rule: every Sunday, half your study time revises the week that just passed before anything new opens.
- If a topic fails the third revision, it goes on a red list — those get re-tested in mock-analysis week.

The test of a good note: you can revise the entire subject from it in one sitting before Prelims. If your notes cannot be read in a day, they are a book, not a weapon.

SECTION 13

Answer Writing & the Fifteen Fatal Mistakes

Answer writing is a Mains skill, but the habit is built in Prelims year. And most beginner damage is self-inflicted — the list below is where first attempts go to die.

The answer-writing ramp

- November 2026: two answers a week. Copy the structure of toppers' answers from PYQ collections — intro, 3–4 body points, conclusion.
- February–May 2027: one answer a week minimum, even in Prelims mode (it keeps the writing muscle alive).
- After Prelims (June–August): daily answer writing + one full essay a fortnight. That window is short — Mains begins 20 August 2027.

The fifteen fatal mistakes

#	Mistake	The fix
1	Collecting books, Telegram PDFs and 5 YouTube channels	The Section-6 list. One source per subject.
2	Never reading the official syllabus	Print it; read it twice before study begins, monthly after.
3	Studying without PYQs	Skim 5 years before your first book; re-test after each subject.
4	Delaying answer writing to “after the syllabus”	Two answers a week from November.
5	Ignoring CSAT	The Section-10 weekly dose; diagnostic in week one.

#	Mistake	The fix
6	Switching newspapers / compilations / "sources"	One of each; the problem is revision, not source.
7	No revision cycle — read once, move on	Revise within 7 days, again in 3–4 weeks, again in the final lap.
8	Optional dithering till February	Hard deadline: 31 October 2026.
9	Note-copying — notes that equal the book	One-line notes, your own words, static links only.
10	Treating coaching as a substitute for study	Coaching gives direction; selection comes from your desk.
11	Mock tests started "next month" forever	Weekly from mid-March; error log every time.
12	All-day current affairs binging	60–90 minutes, one paper, syllabus-linked (Section 9).
13	Comparing pace with peers and resetting monthly	Track yourself against the Section-13 plan only.
14	No rest day, then a lost fortnight	One half-day off weekly; sleep is preparation.
15	Applying on 2 February and hitting errors	Apply in week one of the window (Section 12).

SECTION 14

The Application Window: 13 January – 2 February 2027

A rejected form ends the attempt before it begins. The process runs on upsconline.nic.in through One Time Registration (OTR) → Universal Registration Number (URN) → Common Application Form. Do it in week one.

Application checklist — tick every box

■	Before 13 January: complete your OTR on upsconline.nic.in and generate your URN — it carries your basic profile and saves scramble-time.
■	On notification day: read the CSE 2027 notice fully — eligibility, vacancies, centres and rules for this cycle are final here.
■	Verify age and attempts one more time against the 2027 notification's dates (the rules in Section 4 shift a year with the cycle).
■	Photograph: taken within 10 days of applying, with your name and the date printed on it — this exact spec is enforced.
■	Photo ID: decide the one ID you will carry (Aadhaar / Passport / Voter ID / Driving Licence / PAN) — you must carry this same ID to the exam hall.
■	Signature: scan per the portal's spec; keep the file small and clean.
■	Centre choices: fill several — centres are allotted, not guaranteed.

■	Fee: ■100 online (net banking / card / UPI). Female, SC, ST and PwBD candidates are exempt.
■	Submit in week one. No withdrawal is permitted after submission, and 2 February 6:00 PM is unforgiving.
■	Save and print the final submitted application; keep the registration ID safe.

After Prelims results: if you qualify, the Mains window asks for a Detailed Application Form plus ■200 (exempt categories as above) within about ten days of the Prelims result — watch for it; missing that window forfeits your Mains seat.

SECTION 15

The Other Two Stages: Mains & Interview

Prelims is the gate; the rank is decided by 2025 marks you write and speak after it. You do not prepare for these stages now — but you must not build a plan that makes them impossible later.

The Mains reality (20 August 2027 onwards)

- Nine papers over five days, three hours each, descriptive, written by hand — speed and stamina are separate skills that only come from writing practice.
- Essay (250): two essays, and the scoring difference between an average essay and a structured one is enormous. Start one practice essay a fortnight from June 2027.
- GS papers reward structure: intro, 3–4 analysed points with data or committee names, a forward-looking conclusion. That is why current-affairs linkage (Section 9) starts now.
- GS-IV Ethics is mostly case-study technique — the easiest paper to prepare late, once the answer-writing habit exists.
- Optional (500 marks): your Section-7 deadline protects this. In June–August 2027 you finish, revise and write PYQ answers — not learn from scratch.

The Interview (275 marks, early 2028)

- About twice the number of vacancies are summoned — clearing Mains means a real chance at the list.
- It carries no minimum qualifying marks, but swings ranks by huge margins: 275 marks against a written total of 1750 means each interview mark is worth about 6 written marks.
- Your Detailed Application Form (DAF) is the question bank: home state, graduation subjects, hobbies, service preference — keep living a real life alongside preparation so you have real answers.
- Start a small habit now: 15 minutes of reading on your home district and graduation subjects weekly. In January 2028 that becomes your interview core.

SECTION 16

Your Weekly Tracker

Photocopy or redraw this table every week. Sunday evening, 10 minutes: fill it honestly. Three red weeks in a row means something structural is wrong — fix the schedule, not your self-respect.

Field	Plan	Done	Verdict
Newspaper notes (days)	7		

Field	Plan	Done	Verdict
Static subject — chapters/pages			
Optional — chapters/pages			
MCQs attempted / score			
CSAT sectional done?	1		
Answers written	2		
Revision of previous week done?	Yes		
Mock (from mid-March) + analysis	1		
Error-log entries			

The first seven days — start today

Day	Action
Day 1	Download the Prelims + Mains syllabus from upsc.gov.in. Read both twice. Highlight what you already know.
Day 2	Skim the last 5 years of Prelims GS papers — don't solve, just observe what UPSC actually asks.
Day 3	Set up the booklist (Section 6). Order or download NCERTs; buy Laxmikanth and Spectrum only.
Day 4	Take one CSAT paper cold, timed. Log the score — it decides your Section-10 dose.
Day 5	Choose your newspaper. Read day one with the syllabus beside you; make 5 one-line notes.
Day 6	Fix your timetable (Section 8) and put the five Section-3 dates in your phone with alerts.
Day 7	Begin Polity: NCERT first, then Laxmikanth. First entry in the weekly tracker. You are moving.

SECTION 17

FAQs & Official Resources

The questions every beginner asks in week one, answered straight — and where to verify anything this planner says.

Is eight months enough for a serious first attempt?

For a full-time aspirant, yes — a focused eight-month runway with three revision cycles and a proper mock season is a proven first-attempt formula. For a working professional with 25 hours a week it is workable but tight; many succeed, and the same plan stretched to 12–18 months for CSE 2028 is stronger still. What kills candidates is not the runway length; it is drifting through the first three months.

Coaching or self-study?

Both produce toppers. Coaching's value is direction, tests and discipline — not information, which is free and official. If you can hold a schedule yourself with this planner's structure, a test series (from mid-March) and PYQ books are the only paid tools you strictly need.

I am from a Hindi medium / regional medium background — does that change anything?

The Prelims papers are set in Hindi and English. For Mains you may answer in any Eighth Schedule language, and the Essay and language papers respect that choice. Choose your Optional and answer-language early and buy your standard books in that language — the plan itself does not change.

Official resources — always the final word

- upsc.gov.in — notifications, the annual exam calendar, syllabus PDF, PYQ papers, cut-offs and results.
- upsconline.nic.in — One Time Registration and all application activity (opens for CSE 2027 on 13 January 2027).
- ncert.nic.in — every NCERT textbook, free and legal.
- pib.gov.in — official press releases behind the schemes you read in the newspaper.
- indiabudget.gov.in — the Union Budget and Economic Survey each February.

Every date, pattern, fee and cut-off in this planner was verified against official UPSC publications as of 19 September 2026. The CSE 2027 notification (13 January 2027) is the final authority for rules, vacancies and dates — verify your eligibility against it before you apply.

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